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PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR

DEVON CONWAY
NEW ZEALAND
Conway will be the mainstay for New Zealand in the initial stage when Kane Williamson might be absent. He has a decent record in India, knows the conditions well

venues during the group stages (see *The Long Road to Victory*). And every game, India will start as favourites owing to their current ODI world No. 1 ranking and the fine form they've shown the past month.

The venues will help too. The England and Australian line-ups, bred on fast, seaming conditions, will face India on the spin-friendly pitches of Lucknow and Chennai, respectively. Pakistan, with its pace-bowling strength and slightly inexperienced batting, will prefer a low-scoring game to give themselves the best chance to beat India. But, expect Ahmedabad, the venue of the India-Pakistan clash, to offer a track with plenty of runs in it, favouring India's strength in batting in the process. Only New Zealand and South Africa, in Dharamshala and Eden Gardens, respectively, could nullify India's home advantage to a certain extent as both opponents will relish the seam-friendly conditions on offer at these venues. Though, even here, with the Indian pace-bowling attack of Bumrah, Shami, Siraj and Pandya firing on all cylinders, the Indians would have their noses in front.

THE VENUES WILL HELP... BUT WITH THE PACE BATTERY OF BUMRAH, SHAMI, SIRAJ AND PANDYA FIRING, INDIA SHOULD HAVE THEIR NOSES IN FRONT ALMOST ANYWHERE

But India wouldn't want to rely on home conditions alone. In coach Rahul Dravid, a man who always trusted his methods and process as a player, they have someone who will have prepared a 360-degree roadmap, with data-driven strategies and match-ups forming an integral part of the campaign. There is a lot at stake for Dravid too. The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) brought in the seventh-highest run-scorer in the history of international cricket with only one goal in mind: landing a trophy at the world level. Dravid's two years at the helm have been marred by exits in the semis of the 2022 T20 World Cup and the loss in the final of the 2023 World Test Championship (WTC). This, then, could well be the Wall's last hurrah. "I think it is very clear that for the Indian public, nothing short of a World Cup win will do. For Dravid and even Rohit

HARDIK PANDYA
INDIA
Could Pandya be the powerhouse that Yuvraj Singh was in 2011? The all-rounder's presence in the lower order is vital, while his bowling can topple the best batters

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